



DONOT APT TARGETS EUROPEAN DIPLOMATS WITH LOPTIKMOD MALWARE

Vairav Security News Report

Date: July 10, 2025

Vairav Cyber Threat Intelligence Team

Vairav Technology Security Pvt. Ltd.

Thirbam Sadak 148

Baluwatar, Kathmandu

Phone: +977 4541540

Mobile: +977-9820105900

Email: sales@vairavtech.com

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

A suspected India-linked threat actor **DoNot APT** (aka APT-C-35, Mint Tempest, Origami Elephant, SECTOR02, and Viceroy Tiger) has been observed targeting a **European foreign affairs ministry** using a customized malware called **LoptikMod**. This represents an escalation in the group's operations beyond its usual South Asian focus and highlights the increasing geopolitical reach of state-aligned espionage campaigns.

KEY CAMPAIGN DETAILS

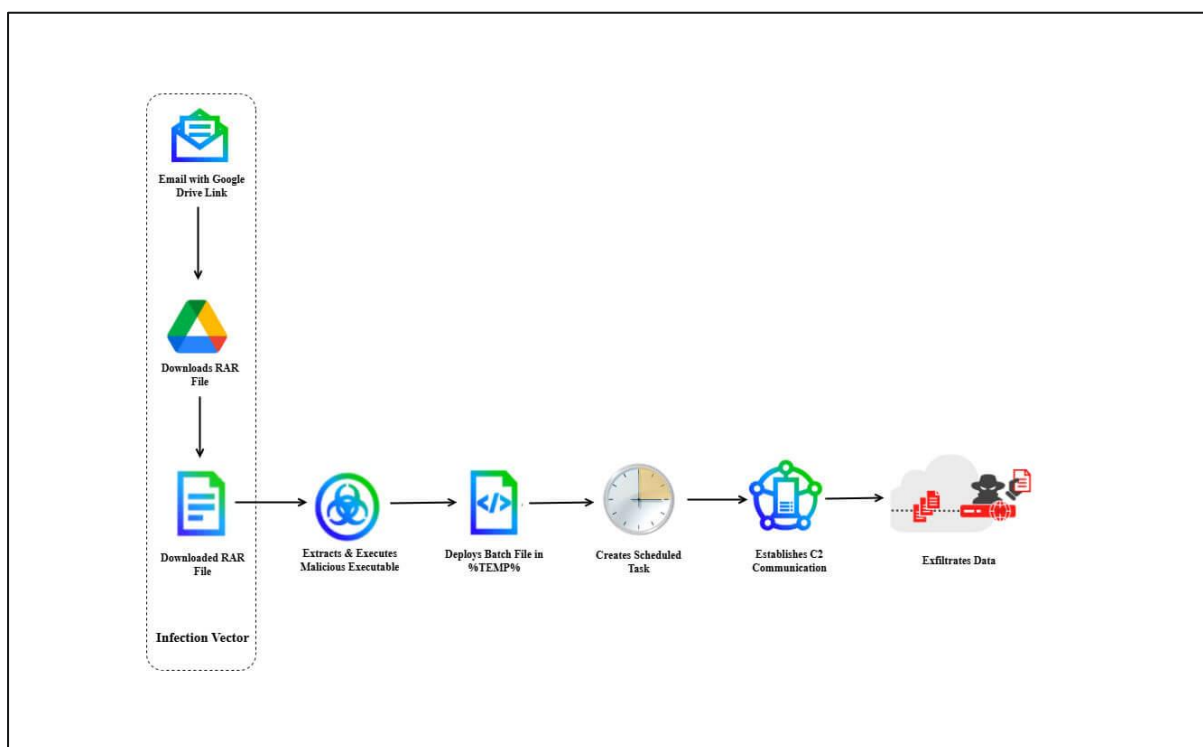


Figure 1: Attack Scenario

- **Initial Vector:** Spear-phishing email impersonating a **defense official** regarding a diplomatic visit (e.g., Italian Defense Attaché to Dhaka).
- **Delivery Method:** Malicious **Google Drive link** distributing a **RAR archive**.
- **Payload:** The RAR contains an **executable disguised as a PDF**, which launches **LoptikMod** malware.
- **Infection Chain:**
 - Establishes **persistence via scheduled tasks**
 - Connects to a **C2 server** to receive commands
 - Collects system metadata and **exfiltrates sensitive data**

- Employs **anti-VM techniques** and **ASCII obfuscation**
- Enforces **single-instance execution** to avoid redundancy

THREAT ACTOR PROFILE – DONOT APT

- **Active Since:** 2016
- **Primary Targets:** Government bodies, foreign ministries, NGOs, and defense organizations
- **Region of Focus:** South Asia and now extending to **European diplomatic targets**
- **Known Tools:** YTY, GEdit, and now **LoptikMod**

MALWARE FOCUS: LOPTIKMOD

- **Custom RAT** (Remote Access Trojan) used exclusively by DoNot APT since **2018**
- Capable of:
 - Maintaining **long-term access**
 - **Receiving modular payloads**
 - **Obfuscating execution** in virtualized environments
 - **Ensuring stealthy persistence** on compromised machines

INFRASTRUCTURE & CURRENT STATUS

- The campaign's **C2 server is currently inactive**, suggesting:
 - Temporary takedown
 - Migration to new infrastructure
 - Operational pause
- This limits insight into real-time data exfiltration and command structure.

DoNot APTs shift from South Asia to **European foreign ministries** suggests a broader geopolitical strategy tied to intelligence gathering. The combination of spear-phishing precision, anti-analysis features, and stealthy remote access demonstrates a **mature, espionage-focused threat**.

Organizations handling **international affairs, foreign policy, or diplomatic matters** should consider this a **high-priority threat** and conduct proactive threat hunting based on known DoNot APT TTPs.

RECOMMENDATIONS

- **Email Security Awareness:** Train users to verify diplomatic or official emails, especially those containing Google Drive links or suspicious attachments.
- **Blocklist Artifacts:** Prevent execution of .exe files masquerading as PDFs inside archives.
- **Deploy Behavior Monitoring:** Use EDR solutions to track persistence mechanisms such as Scheduled Tasks and anomalous network connections.
- **Monitor for LoptikMod Artifacts:** Watch for file names mimicking documents and **ASCII-obfuscated scripts**.
- **Isolate Hosts:** If infection is suspected, isolate endpoints and inspect for long-dormant persistence tasks.

REFERENCES

<https://www.trellix.com/blogs/research/from-click-to-compromise-unveiling-the-sophisticated-attack-of-donot-apt-group-on-southern-european-government-entities/>
<https://thehackernews.com/2025/07/donot-apt-expands-operations-targets.html>

Vairav Technology Security Pvt. Ltd.**Cyber Defender from the land of Gurkha**

Thirbam Sadak 148, Baluwatar

Kathmandu, Nepal

Phone: +977-01-4541540

Mobile: +977-9820105900

Email: sales@vairavtech.com

Website: <https://vairavtech.com>